ExecuteSpec Web Agent Remote Sandbox Operator

Post-deploy persona and adversarial UX audit - June 29, 2026

Environment: https://dev.executespec.ai/agent. Deployed SHA: 2766f3eeebecbf2d6e65e28df62d5e53bd53790d. Evidence was captured from the authenticated deployed dev app after the manual local deploy health check returned UP.

Scope and limits

- This audit uses fresh deployed screenshots only. Older local smoke screenshots are not used as proof.

- No paid or credit-consuming sandbox run was started during this UX audit, so plan approval, code execution, PR creation, and final evidence views are reviewed from available UI states and source-verified implementation, not a newly completed live run.

- Screenshots can reveal layout, hierarchy, copy, visible accessibility risks, and conversion friction. They do not prove full keyboard, screen reader, latency, or backend run reliability.

- Competitor comparison uses official public docs URLs listed in Sources, not hands-on trials inside competitor products.

Executive verdict

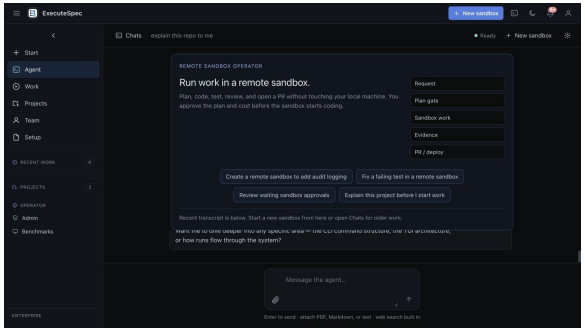
- The pivot is materially better: the first screen now says remote sandbox operator, explains the gate, and gives obvious sandbox CTAs.

- The product still feels like an internal operator console, not a high-conversion cloud-agent surface. Dense dark UI, old transcript leakage, provider and credits jargon, and weak proof of what happens after approval are the biggest remaining blockers.

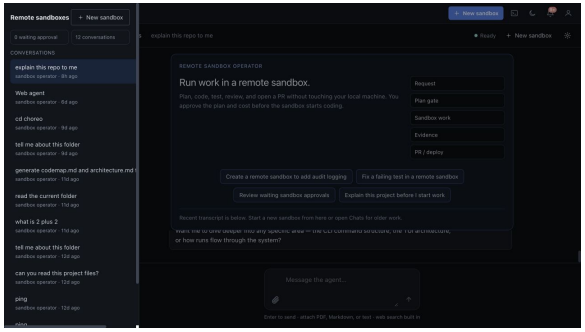
- Mobile is serviceable for review and approval, but not yet strong for first-time conversion. The top-level mobile plus button is ambiguous even though the in-agent New sandbox label is fixed.

- Compared with Codex Cloud, Claude Code, Cursor, Devin, and Replit Agent, ExecuteSpec now has a clearer remote-sandbox noun, but still undersells outcome proof: branch, PR, tests, cost, and rollback should be visible before the user asks.

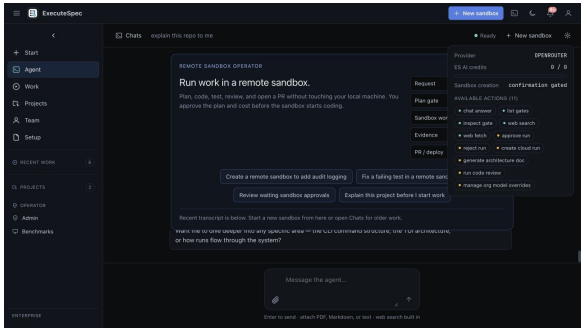
Evidence contact sheet



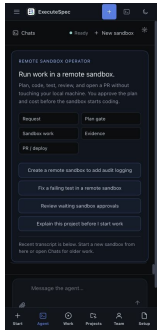
S1 - Desktop entry. Remote sandbox operator intro, workflow steps, old transcript docked below, New sandbox CTA.



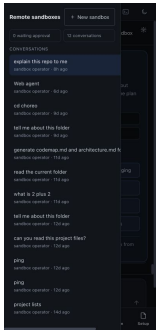
S2 - Desktop drawer. Remote sandboxes drawer, waiting approvals count, conversation grouping.



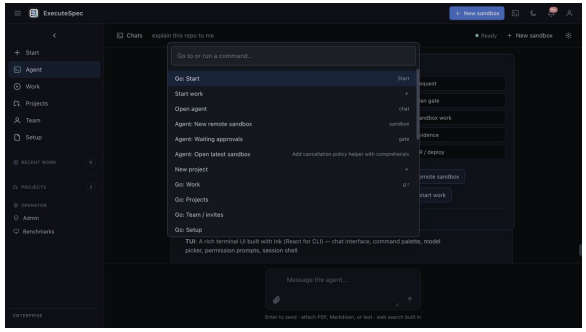
S3 - Settings popover. Provider, ES AI credits, sandbox creation gate, available action list.



S4 - Mobile entry. Mobile operator intro, labeled Chats and New sandbox controls, fixed workflow chips.



S5 - Mobile drawer. Mobile remote sandbox drawer and session list.



S6 - Command palette. Command palette entries for new remote sandbox, waiting approvals, latest sandbox.

Persona test results

First-time founder / buyer

Task	Understand what Web Agent does and decide whether to start a remote sandbox.
Evidence	S1, S6
What works	The headline finally names the product job. The workflow chips reduce ambiguity: request, plan gate, sandbox work, evidence, PR/deploy.
Adversarial review	The screen still assumes a user already trusts ExecuteSpec. There is no compact proof block saying what repo, branch, test command, PR target, and cost ceiling will be controlled before the sandbox starts. Old transcript content competes with conversion.
Severity	High conversion risk
Recommended fix	Add a persistent What will happen rail before the composer: repo, branch, plan gate, cost cap, PR destination, no local files touched. Collapse old transcript behind Recent answer for new sessions.
Verdict	Improved but still not buyer-grade.

Senior backend engineer

Task	Start a remote PR-style fix without local setup.
Evidence	S1, S3, S6
What works	The remote sandbox language is aligned with the desired mental model. Command palette exposes a direct New remote sandbox action.
Adversarial review	The engineer still has to infer operational details: clone source, branch naming, test execution, build logs, and whether failures are retryable. Settings exposes action internals but not the actual sandbox contract.
Severity	Medium-high
Recommended fix	Add a Sandbox contract card near the composer: isolated clone, branch name, test runner, PR behavior, evidence artifacts, cancellation behavior. Keep provider/action diagnostics behind settings.
Verdict	Usable by an insider, under-specified for a skeptical engineer.

Engineering manager / budget approver

Task	Review whether a proposed sandbox is worth approving.
Evidence	S2, S3
What works	The drawer has a waiting-approval counter, which supports approval-oriented work. The settings popover shows gating state.
Adversarial review	Approval work is only a count, not a queue with dollars, risk, repo, owner, age, or expected blast radius. ES AI credits 0/0 is more alarming than useful if the user does not know whether it blocks work.
Severity	High for manager conversion
Recommended fix	Turn waiting approvals into a true review queue: spec title, repo, estimated credits/USD, risk tags, owner, age, approve/reject buttons, and proof of why approval is needed.
Verdict	The navigation exists; the decision surface is not yet strong.

Existing CLI / VS Code local-hands user

Task	Confirm Web Agent is remote-only while local authority remains in CLI/VS Code.
Evidence	S1, S3
What works	Copy says the sandbox does not touch local machine. The settings/action list keeps local shell affordances out of the Web UI.
Adversarial review	The old transcript includes local hands / remote brain CLI language, which can undermine the remote-sandbox positioning on the Web screen. A local-hands user may think Web Agent is a weaker CLI rather than a different surface.
Severity	Medium
Recommended fix	Show a local-hands handoff affordance only when the requested action needs local file/shell authority. Do not let old CLI explanations dominate Web Agent entry.
Verdict	Boundary is mostly clear, but transcript carryover muddies it.

Security / compliance reviewer

Task	Assess data and authority boundaries before allowing usage.
Evidence	S1, S3
What works	The no-local-files promise is visible. Confirmation-gated sandbox creation is a good policy signal.
Adversarial review	The UI does not show data-retention, repo permission, secret handling, outbound network, or PR write authority details at the moment of intent. Available actions are shown as raw capabilities, not policy-enforced scopes.
Severity	High for enterprise trust
Recommended fix	Add a compact Security boundary disclosure before plan approval: isolated workspace, token source, repo write permissions, secret handling, retention, network policy, audit trail.
Verdict	Promising language, insufficient trust proof.

Mobile on-call approver

Task	Open Web Agent on mobile, find pending approvals, and understand current state.
Evidence	S4, S5
What works	Mobile layout no longer hides Chats/New sandbox labels inside the Agent bar. The drawer is readable and session rows remain tappable.
Adversarial review	The top navigation still has an icon-only plus button. The drawer is long, dark, and scroll-heavy; no priority ordering exists. Approver context requires too much reading.
Severity	Medium
Recommended fix	For mobile, prioritize a compact approval inbox over history. Make the top plus button show text or a tooltip-equivalent label in the open state.
Verdict	Acceptable for checking, weak for confident approval.

Separate adversarial UX review vs competitors

This section compares the visible deployed ExecuteSpec Web Agent against the public positioning and workflow promises in official competitor docs. It is intentionally harsh because the requested output asked for adversarial UX review.

OpenAI Codex Cloud	Clear cloud-agent framing and task delegation. Strong expectation that work happens away from the local machine.	ExecuteSpec now says remote sandbox, but still lacks a one-glance proof model for environment, branch, tests, PR, and cost before action.
Claude Code + GitHub Actions	Developer-native workflow, terminal/GitHub integration, and background automation are positioned close to code review.	ExecuteSpec has stronger plan-gate and evidence ambitions, but the Web Agent UI still buries run mechanics behind console density.
Cursor Agent / Bugbot	Very direct developer workflow: agentic work and PR/bug-review surfaces live near the code editor and repository context.	ExecuteSpec must compensate for being web-first by showing repo/branch/test context more explicitly than an IDE-native agent. It does not yet.
Devin	Markets a persistent AI software engineer with task ownership. The promise is outcome-oriented, not tool-list-oriented.	ExecuteSpec still exposes provider/action plumbing in settings. That is useful for operators, weak for conversion.
Replit Agent	Fast create-build-deploy loop for app builders, with a strong first-run mental model.	ExecuteSpec is more enterprise/PR-gated, but needs a better guided first sandbox and visible post-approval timeline.

Priority fixes after this pass

- P0: Replace old transcript dominance with a compact latest-answer dock and make the composer plus sandbox contract the visual center.
- P0: Build a real approvals queue card, not just a counter: repo, risk, estimate, owner, age, approve/reject.
- P0: Show a pre-run sandbox contract before plan creation: isolated workspace, branch, PR target, test command, cost cap, no local files touched.
- P1: Rename ES AI credits in user-facing areas or explain it inline. 0/0 currently looks broken.
- P1: Add trust boundary details at the plan gate: repo token authority, secrets, retention, audit trail, network policy.
- P1: Make mobile approval-first, not history-first.
- P2: Keep command palette, but add a visible keyboard shortcut and consider promoting pending approvals in the top bar when count is nonzero.

Manual deploy and verification evidence

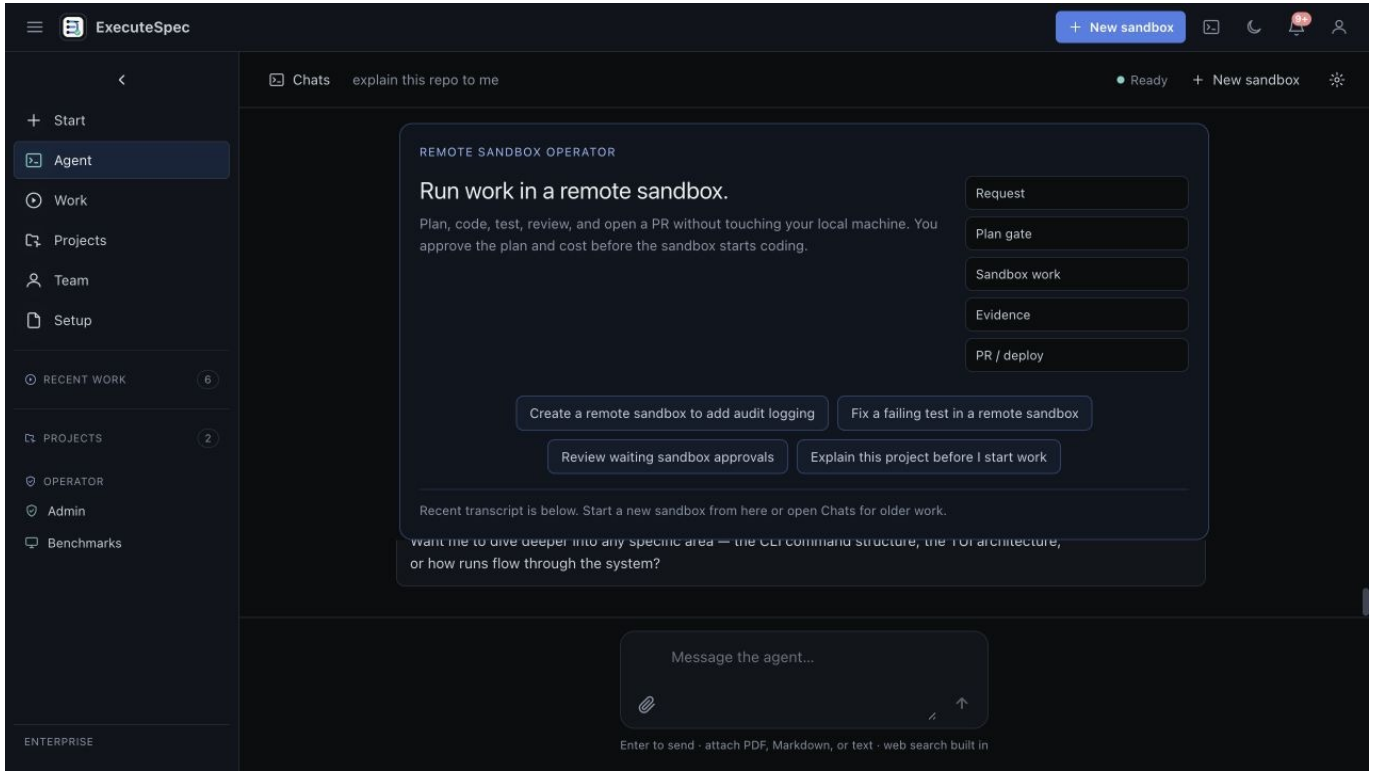
- Local deploy script dry-run passed: dev VM running, deploy bucket readable, IAP/SSH OK.
- Manual deploy command used: CONFIRM_DEPLOY=YES scripts/deploy-local.sh --deploy.
- Deploy succeeded to executespec-dev-vm with JAR gs://executespec-dev-deploy/releases/app-2766f3eeebecbf2d6e65e28df62d5e53bd53790d.jar.
- Post-deploy health: https://dev.executespec.ai/actuator/health returned {"status":"UP"}.
- GCS CURRENT_SHA matched 2766f3eeebecbf2d6e65e28df62d5e53bd53790d.

- Local verification before deploy: targeted backend tests passed, frontend unit tests passed, format check passed, lint passed, frontend build passed, backend compile passed, git diff whitespace check passed.

Sources

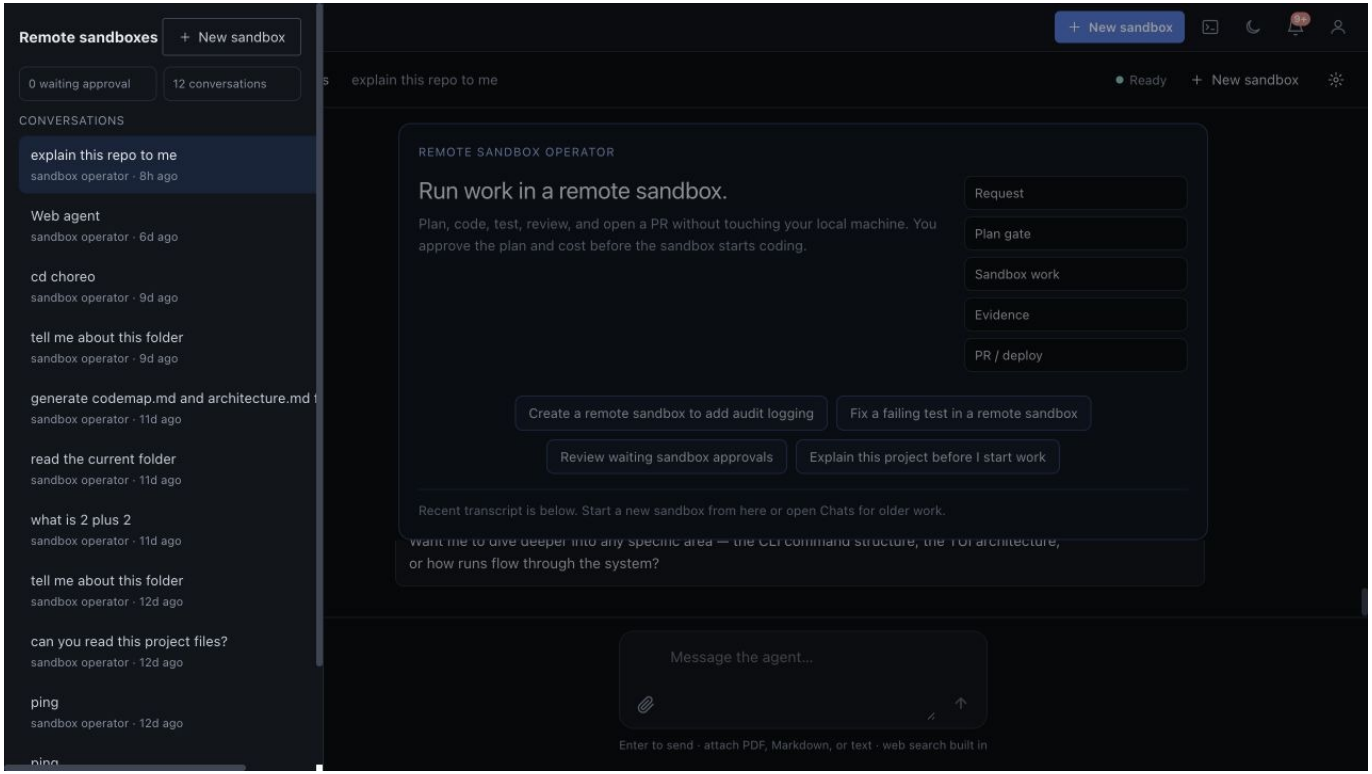
- OpenAI Codex Cloud: https://developers.openai.com/codex/cloud
- Claude Code overview: https://code.claude.com/docs/en/overview
- Claude Code GitHub Actions: https://code.claude.com/docs/en/github-actions
- Cursor Agent overview: https://cursor.com/docs/agent/overview
- Cursor Bugbot: https://cursor.com/docs/bugbot
- Devin intro: https://docs.devin.ai/get-started/devin-intro
- Replit Agent: https://docs.replit.com/replitai/agent

Screenshot appendix - S1: Desktop entry



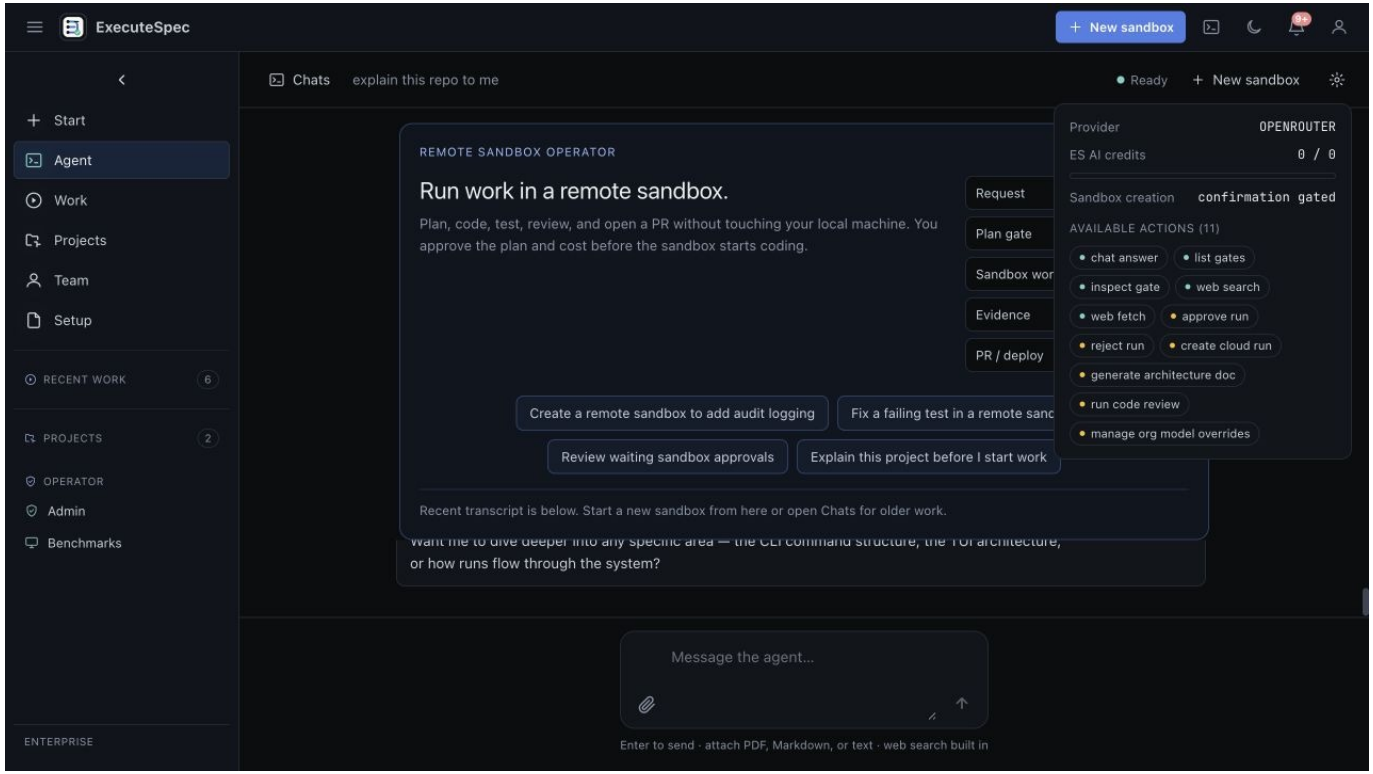
Remote sandbox operator intro, workflow steps, old transcript docked below, New sandbox CTA.

Screenshot appendix - S2: Desktop drawer



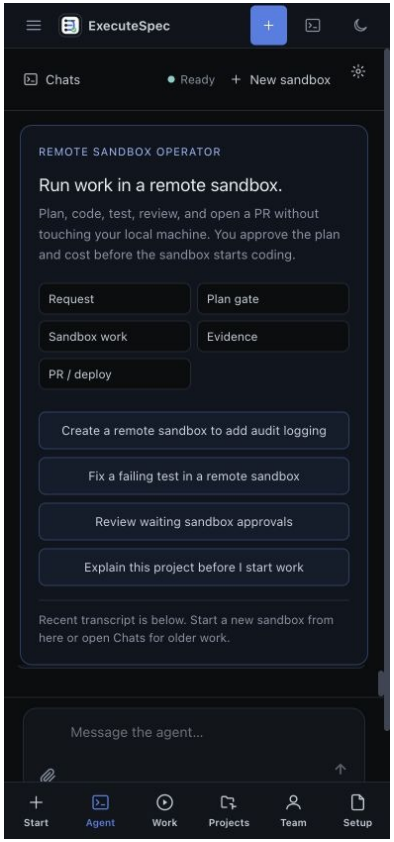
Remote sandboxes drawer, waiting approvals count, conversation grouping.

Screenshot appendix - S3: Settings popover



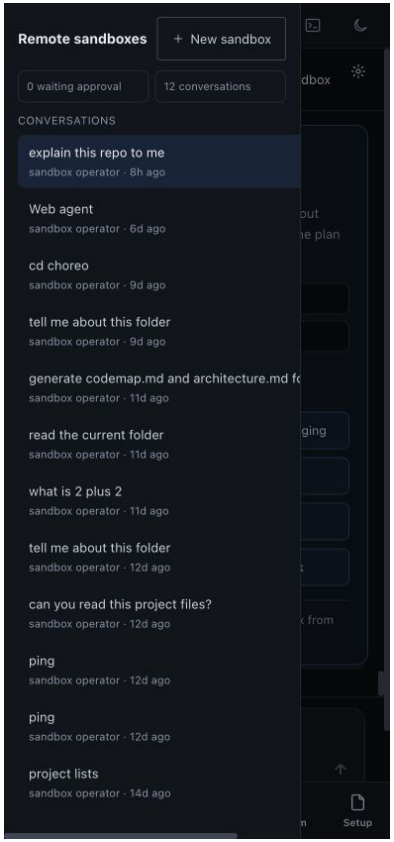
Provider, ES AI credits, sandbox creation gate, available action list.

Screenshot appendix - S4: Mobile entry



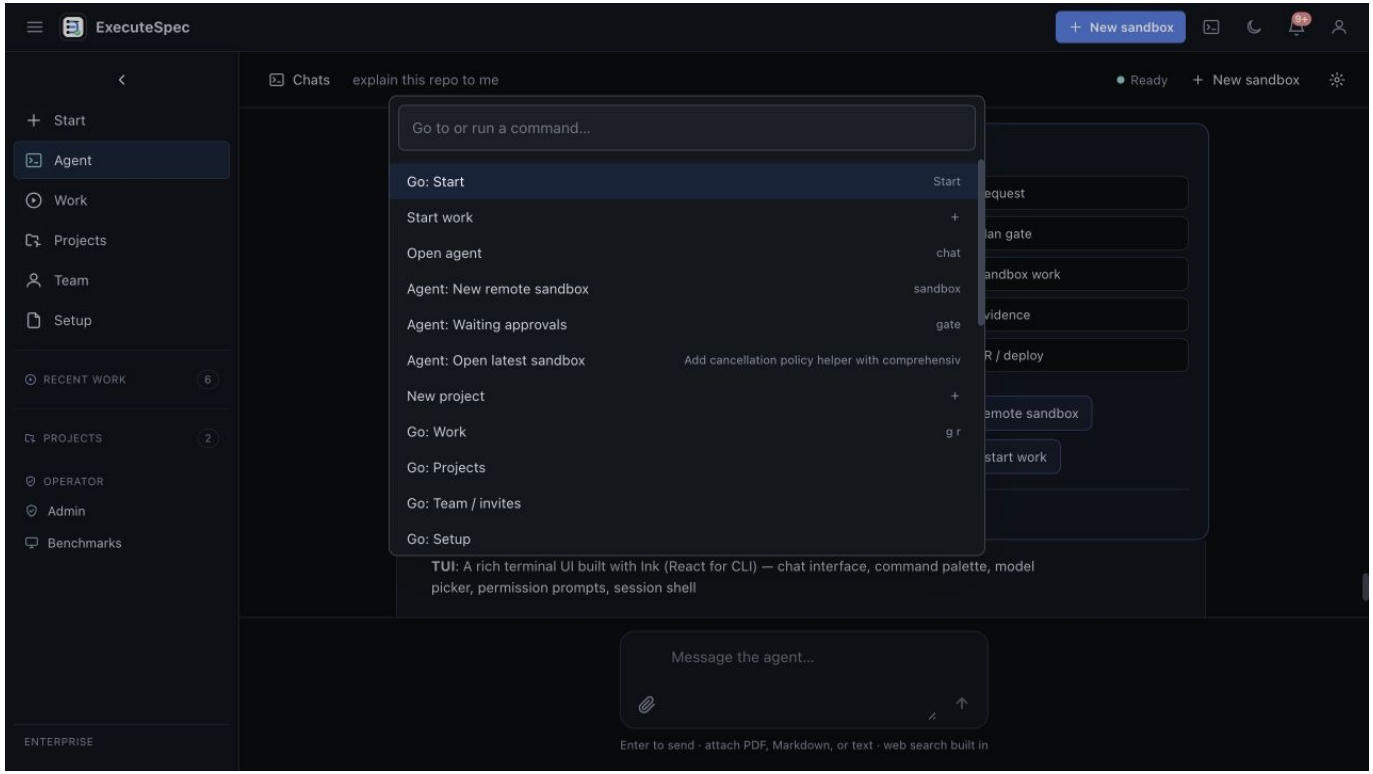
Mobile operator intro, labeled Chats and New sandbox controls, fixed workflow chips.

Screenshot appendix - S5: Mobile drawer



Mobile remote sandbox drawer and session list.

Screenshot appendix - S6: Command palette



Command palette entries for new remote sandbox, waiting approvals, latest sandbox.